NODUS · COMPLETE VAULT GUIDE

Study

Organise a course and turn your own materials into grounded practice.

The Study vault keeps subjects, schedules, notes, imported materials, recordings, concepts, questions and spaced review within one private learning workspace.

EDITION	English
VERSION	Nodus 4.1
UPDATED	14 August 2026
AUDIENCE	University and lifelong learners managing substantial course material.

Contents

Core operation, configuration and the complete vault workflow.

PART I · FOUNDATION

Core Nodus workflow

These operating principles apply to every vault. They establish the local-first data boundary, source workflow, optional model configuration and recovery discipline used throughout this manual.

START HERE

1 Welcome to Nodus

Nodus is a local-first desktop workspace for research, teaching and study. Work is organised into focused vaults that share one private engine.

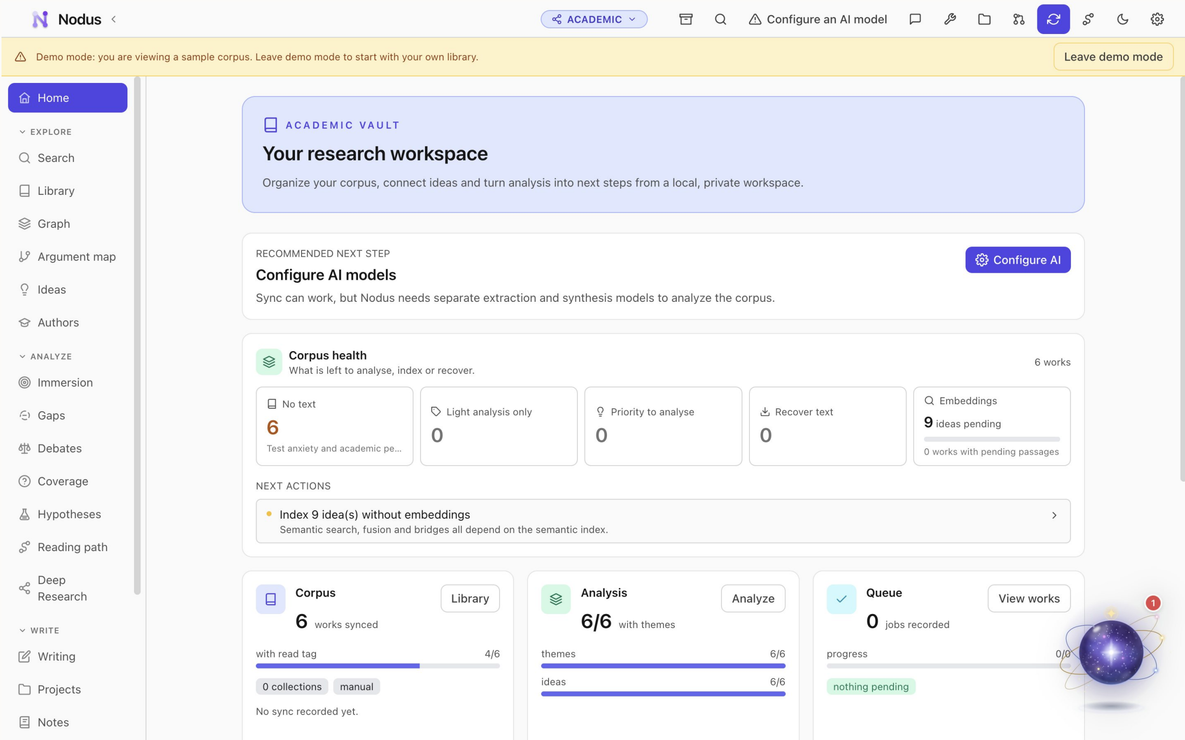
A vault changes the navigation, workflows and assistant context without changing the core promises: your database and indexes remain on your computer, accounts are optional, and AI runs only when a feature needs it and you have configured a provider.

STEP BY STEP

1. Install the current package for macOS, Windows or Linux from the Nodus release page.
2. Open Nodus and choose the interface language, Nodi style and tutorial path.
3. Create a vault for the kind of work you are doing, or load its sample vault before importing your own material.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Use one vault per coherent project, course, family or dataset.
- Sample vaults are disposable and are the safest way to explore.



English interface shown with the built-in sample vault.

START HERE

2 Create and switch vaults

Create independent workspaces and move between them without mixing their context.

The vault switcher is the boundary between projects. Each vault has its own notes, analysis and domain records, while the global Library can link the same source into compatible vaults without duplicating it.

STEP BY STEP

1. Open the vault switcher from the application header and choose New vault.
2. Name the vault, choose its type and review the short description before confirming.
3. Use the same switcher to move to another vault; Nodus restores the last open section.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Use explicit names such as ‘MA thesis - memory’ or ‘Biology 2026’.
- Changing a vault type after substantial work is not a substitute for creating the correct vault.

ESSENTIALS

3 Navigation and global search

The sidebar exposes the workflow for the active vault; search retrieves material across the relevant local index.

Sections are grouped by intent - explore, analyse and write, or organisation and assessment. Search combines exact keyword matching with semantic retrieval when an embedding model is configured, and results preserve links to their source.

STEP BY STEP

1. Choose a section in the left sidebar; the active section is highlighted.
2. Open Search and enter at least two meaningful characters or a natural-language concept.
3. Filter or inspect a result, then follow its source link to the document, record, person or note.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Search for concepts, not only exact titles.
- Rebuild an index from Settings if recently imported content does not appear.

ESSENTIALS

4 Library, sources and reader

Keep preserved originals beside clean reading copies, citations, highlights and extracted evidence.

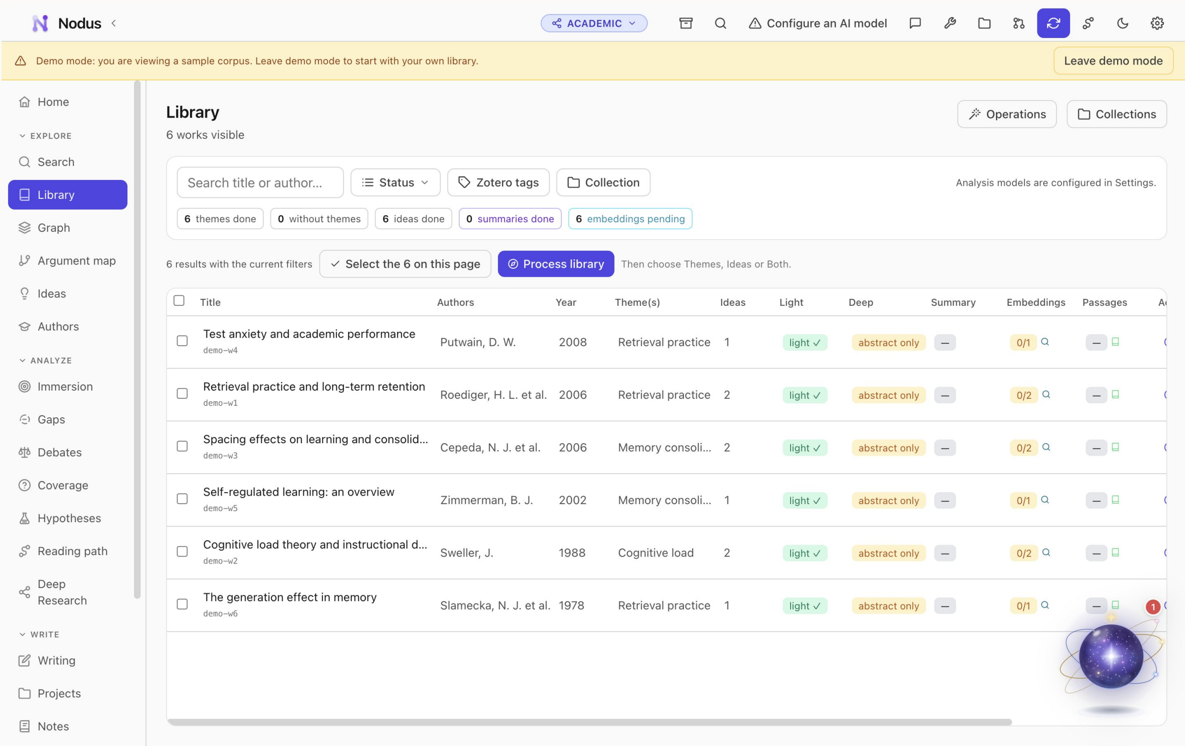
The cross-vault Library can mirror Zotero, import RIS, BibTeX and CSL JSON, or accept files directly. Nodus preserves the original attachment and creates searchable derivatives. Compatible sources can be linked to several vaults without copying the original.

STEP BY STEP

1. Open Library and add a local file, import bibliographic data or connect Zotero.
2. Place the item in a collection and add useful tags; wait for extraction and indexing to finish.
3. Open the item, choose the clean reading copy or preserved original, then highlight passages and link the item into the active vault.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Keep the preserved original for page-accurate verification.
- Treat automatically extracted text and metadata as a first pass that may need correction.



English interface shown with the built-in sample vault.

CONFIGURATION

5 AI providers and task models

Bring your own cloud key or use compatible local models, with a different model for each task.

Provider keys are stored in the operating-system keychain. Nodus distinguishes deterministic local tools from model-assisted features and shows when content will leave the device. Model preferences can mix providers by extraction, chat, writing and report tasks.

STEP BY STEP

1. Open Settings, then Providers, and configure a cloud key or local endpoint.
2. Use the validation action before saving, then open Models.
3. Assign a suitable model to each task and run a small test on sample content.

GOOD PRACTICE

- A local model improves privacy but may require more memory and time.
- Review every generated claim against its linked evidence.

CONFIGURATION

6 Privacy, backups and recovery

Protect local work with a verified backup and understand exactly when network services are used.

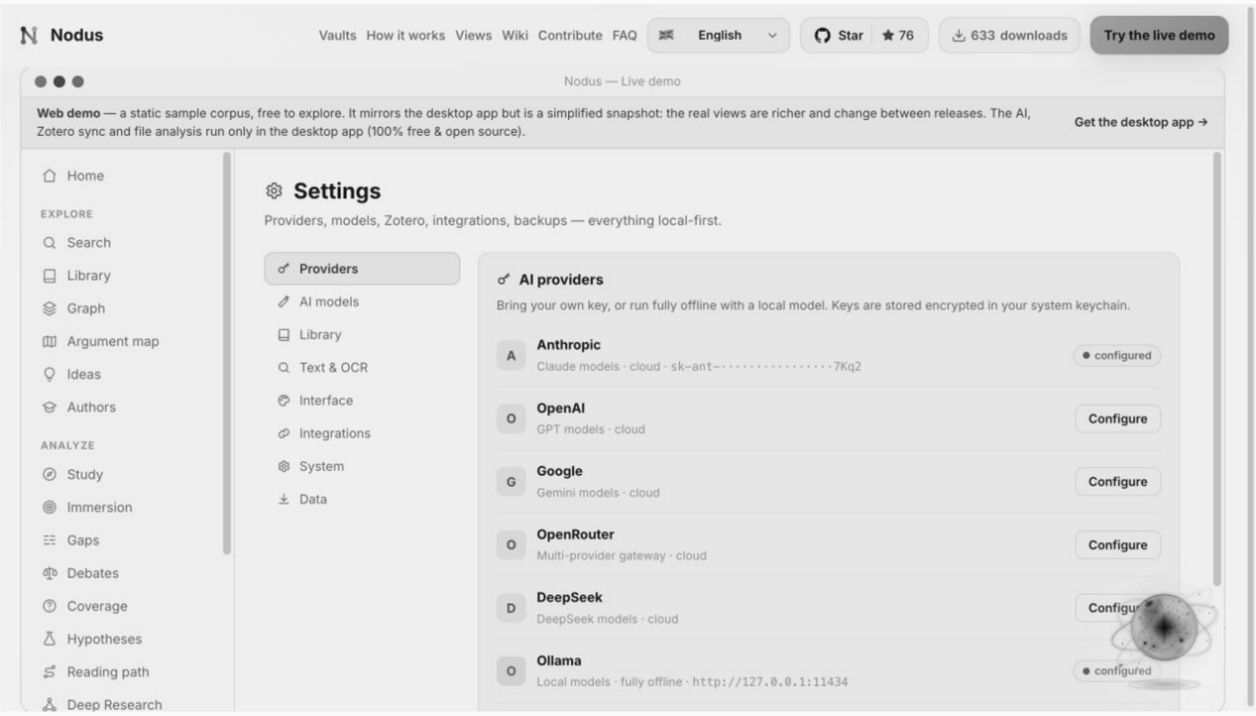
Vault databases, indexes and library files are local by default. Backups can include all vaults and the shared Library. Nodus reports backup health and creates protected recovery copies before major migrations.

STEP BY STEP

1. Open Settings, choose a backup destination and enable automatic backups.
2. Run a manual backup, then use verification to confirm that its manifest and files are readable.
3. Review the privacy notice for each optional online feature before sending content.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Store backups on a different physical device or a trusted encrypted location.
- Do not treat sync as a backup; keep versioned recovery copies.



English interface shown with the built-in sample vault.

CONFIGURATION

7 Toolkit and integrations

Convert, protect, translate, OCR and present documents, or connect Zotero, Word, MCP clients and Nodus Server.

Toolkit utilities are available across vaults. Integrations remain optional: Zotero supplies bibliographic material, Word uses grounded Nodus context, MCP exposes approved local tools, and Nodus Server publishes a selected copy rather than the source vault.

STEP BY STEP

1. Open Toolkit and choose Convert, Protect, Translate, OCR Workspace or PDF Presenter.
2. Select a file from disk or a compatible vault source and review the output options.
3. For an integration, enable only the connector you need and test it with non-sensitive sample content first.

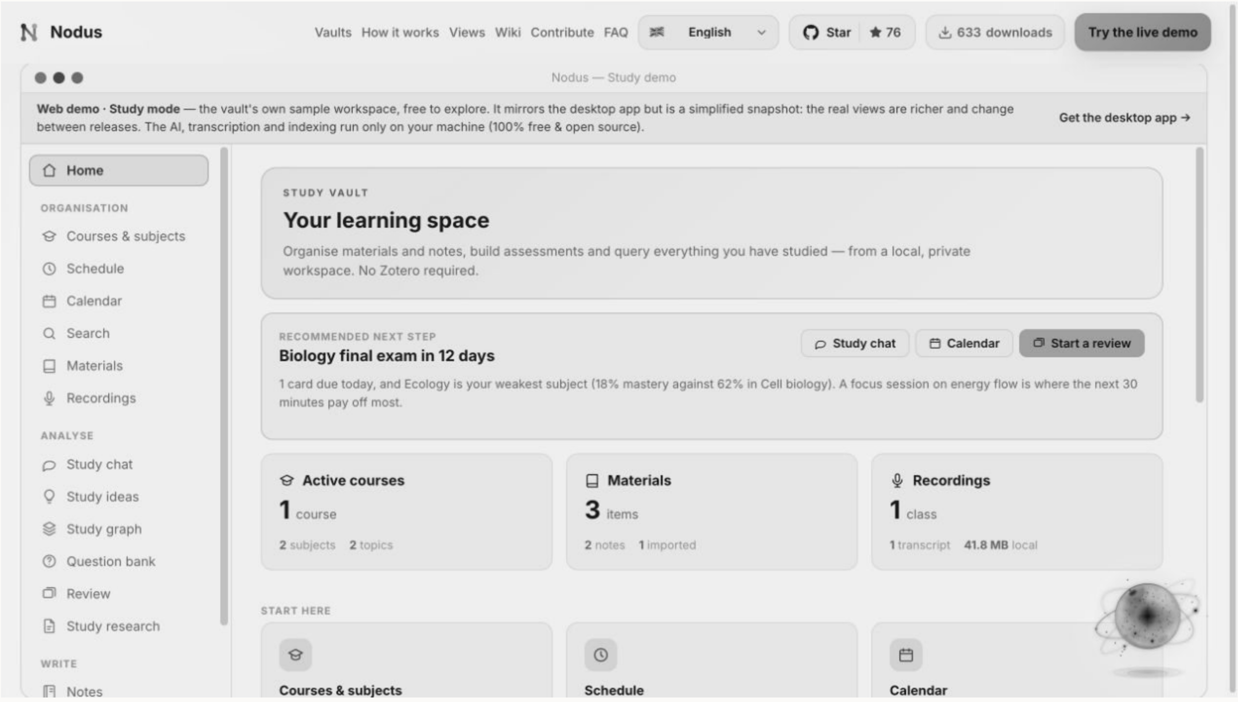
GOOD PRACTICE

- Permanent redaction in Protect is local and irreversible in the exported copy.
- Published server spaces should contain only material intended for their readers.

PART II · VAULT GUIDE

Complete Study workflow

The Study vault keeps subjects, schedules, notes, imported materials, recordings, concepts, questions and spaced review within one private learning workspace.



English interface shown with the built-in sample vault.

ORIENTATION

1 Home and study plan

See courses, materials, upcoming exams, review load and recommended next steps.

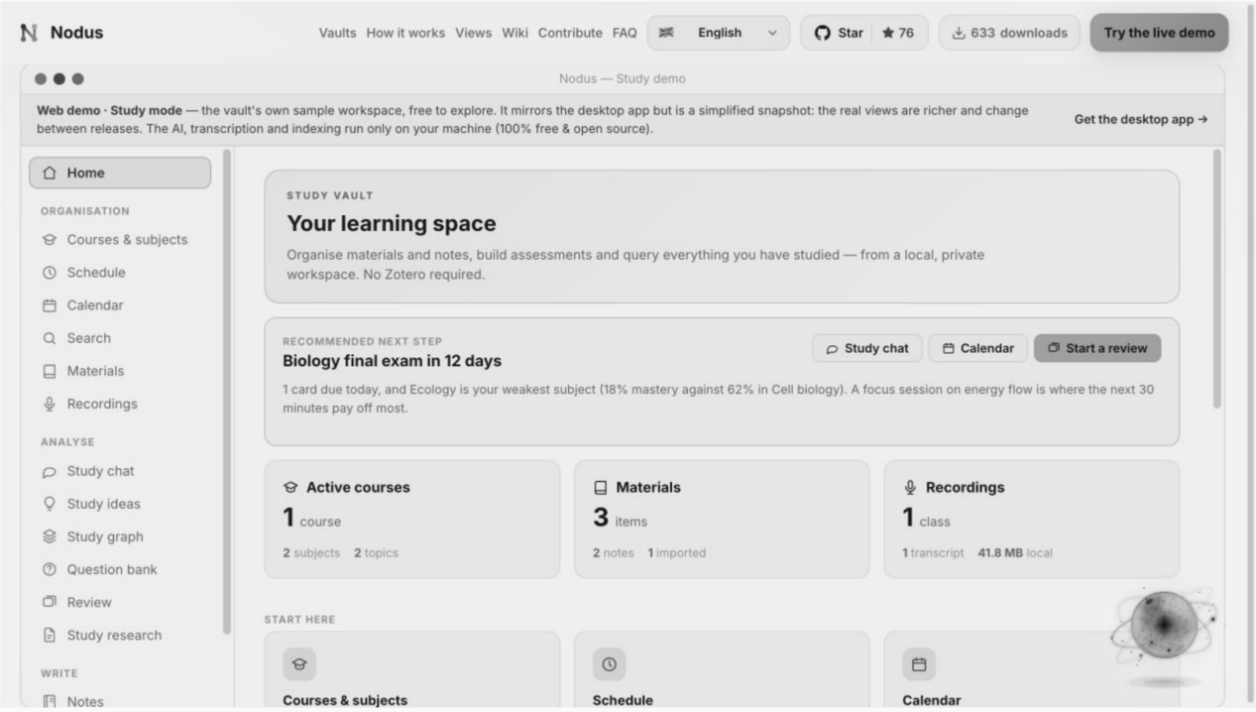
Home consolidates organisation and learning progress without replacing the detailed subject or review views.

STEP BY STEP

1. Check upcoming assessments and scheduled study sessions.
2. Review new material and due review counts.
3. Open the recommended action or a recent note to continue.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Plan from deadlines backwards and keep review sessions small and frequent.



English interface shown with the built-in sample vault.

ORGANISATION

2 Courses, subjects, folders and topics

Build a hierarchy that keeps each subject's materials and AI context separate.

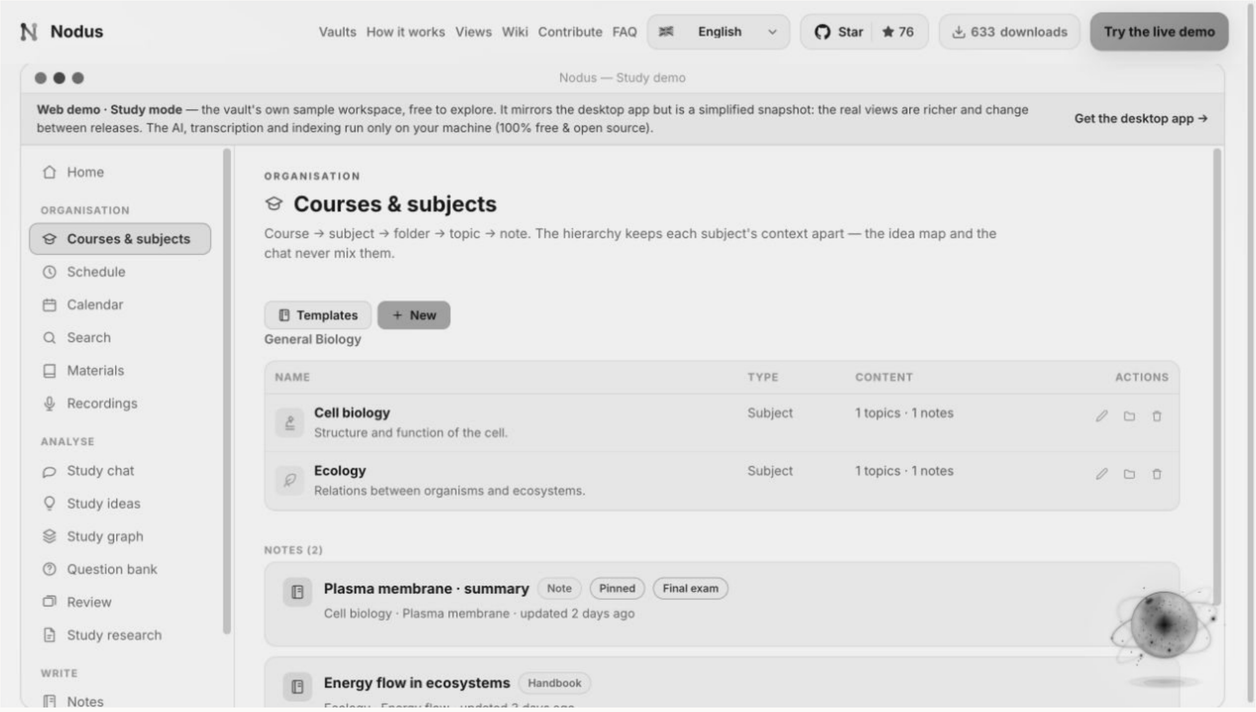
The hierarchy is course to subject to folder to topic to note. Subject colours and icons are reused in schedules, search and learning views.

STEP BY STEP

1. Create the course or degree and add its subjects.
2. Assign a colour and icon, then create only the folders and topics you will use.
3. Move or create notes and materials at the most specific useful level.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Avoid deep empty hierarchies; structure should reduce friction, not add administration.



English interface shown with the built-in sample vault.

ORGANISATION

3 Schedule

Lay subjects across days and time blocks.

Schedule represents the recurring shape of the week and reuses subject identity. Calendar holds dated events and reminders.

STEP BY STEP

1. Choose the active course and week pattern.
2. Add subject blocks to the correct day and morning or afternoon slot.
3. Review collisions and use Calendar for individual deadlines or exceptions.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Leave unscheduled recovery time instead of filling every block.

ORGANISATION

4 Calendar and reminders

Plan classes, deadlines, study sessions and exams with local reminders.

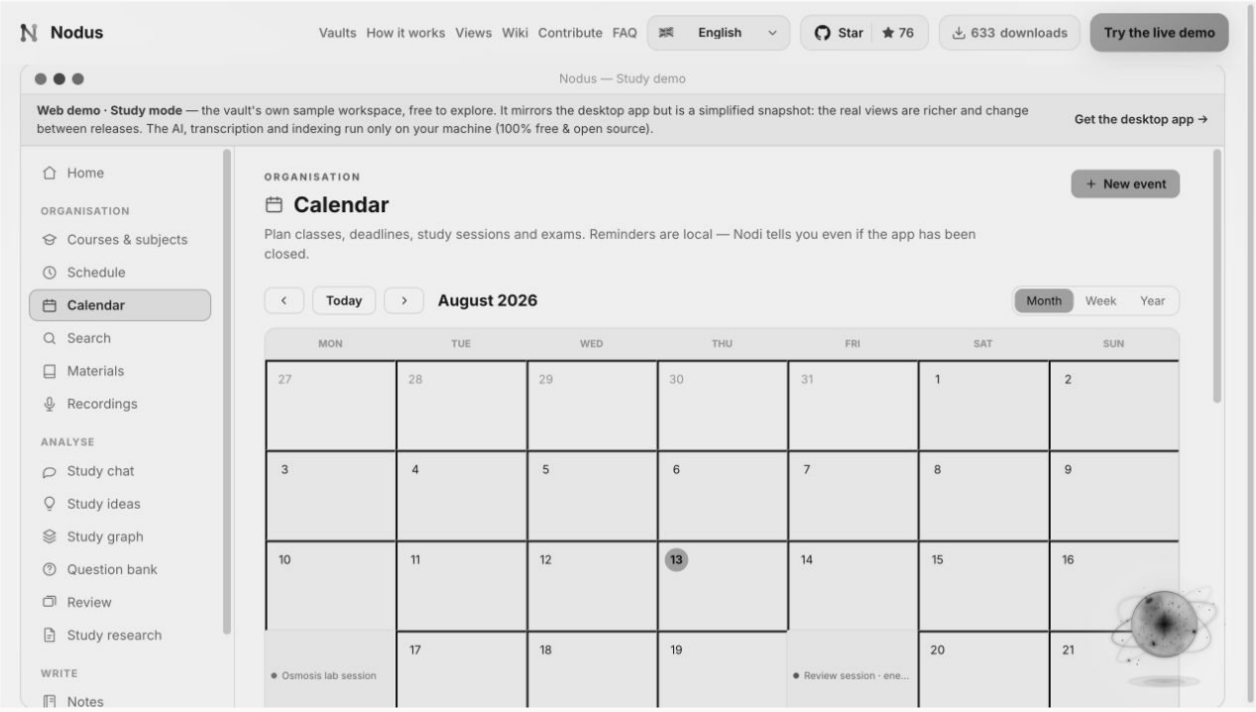
Events can carry a type, icon, link and reminder. Optional calendar export or connection should be reviewed before sharing details outside Nodus.

STEP BY STEP

1. Create an event with a clear title, type, date and time.
2. Link it to a subject, material or note and choose a reminder.
3. Use month or agenda views to rebalance crowded periods.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Schedule the preparation sessions, not only the final deadline.



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ORGANISATION

5 Workspace search

Search notes, materials, transcripts, questions and exams in one local index.

Keyword and semantic retrieval return exact pages or timestamps where available.

STEP BY STEP

1. Enter an exact phrase or concept.
2. Filter by subject or content type.

3. Open the page, note or transcript timestamp that supports the result.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Search your own misconceptions and questions, not only official terminology.

ORGANISATION

6 Materials and focused reading

Import PDFs, documents, slides, EPUBs and audio into the course hierarchy.

Nodus extracts searchable text while preserving the original. Annotations and links connect materials to notes and learning objects.

STEP BY STEP

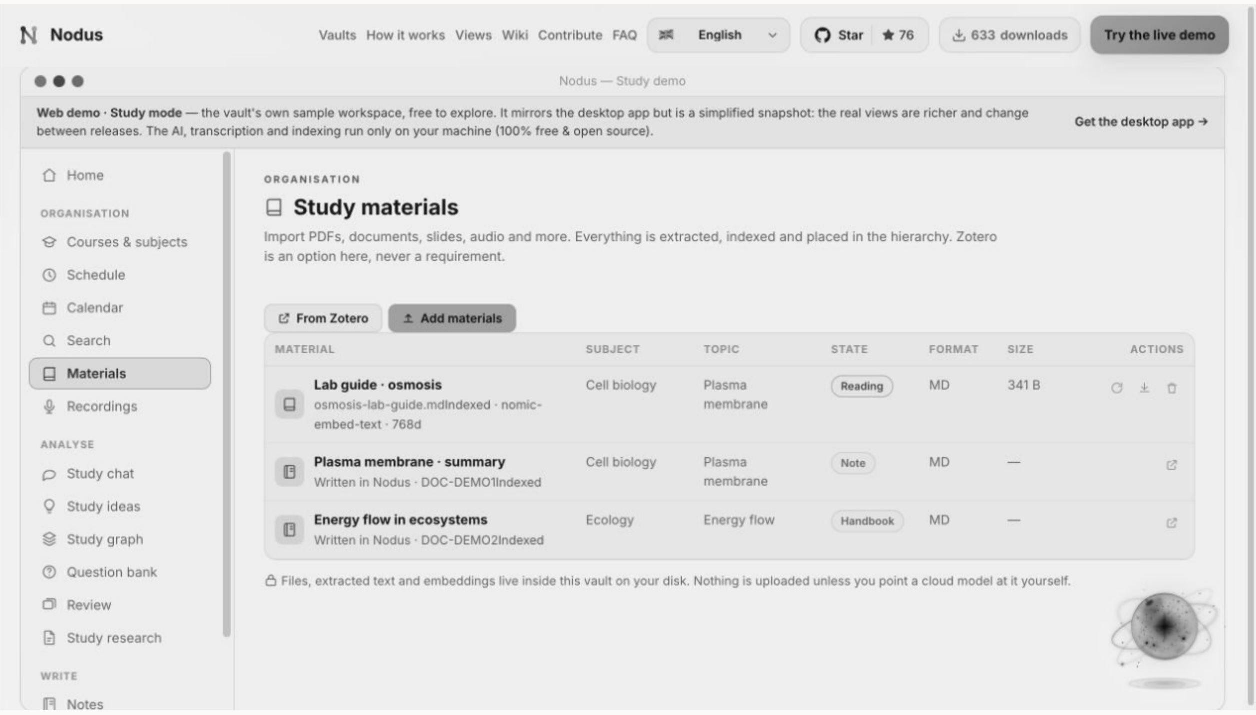
1. Import a file and assign its subject, folder and topic.

2. Wait for extraction, then open the clean copy or preserved original.

3. Highlight and annotate key passages; create a linked note for synthesis.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Prefer active notes and questions over highlighting entire pages.



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ORGANISATION

7 Recordings and local transcripts

Record or import audio, transcribe with local Whisper and jump to exact timestamps.

Recordings can be organised by subject and linked to notes. Local transcription avoids sending classroom audio to a provider.

STEP BY STEP

1. Start a recording with permission or import an existing audio file.
2. Choose local transcription and review the resulting speaker or text segments.
3. Click a transcript line to replay the exact moment and link important segments to a note.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Follow institutional consent rules before recording any class or person.

GUIDED LEARNING

8 Study chat

Ask questions grounded in one subject’s materials and citations.

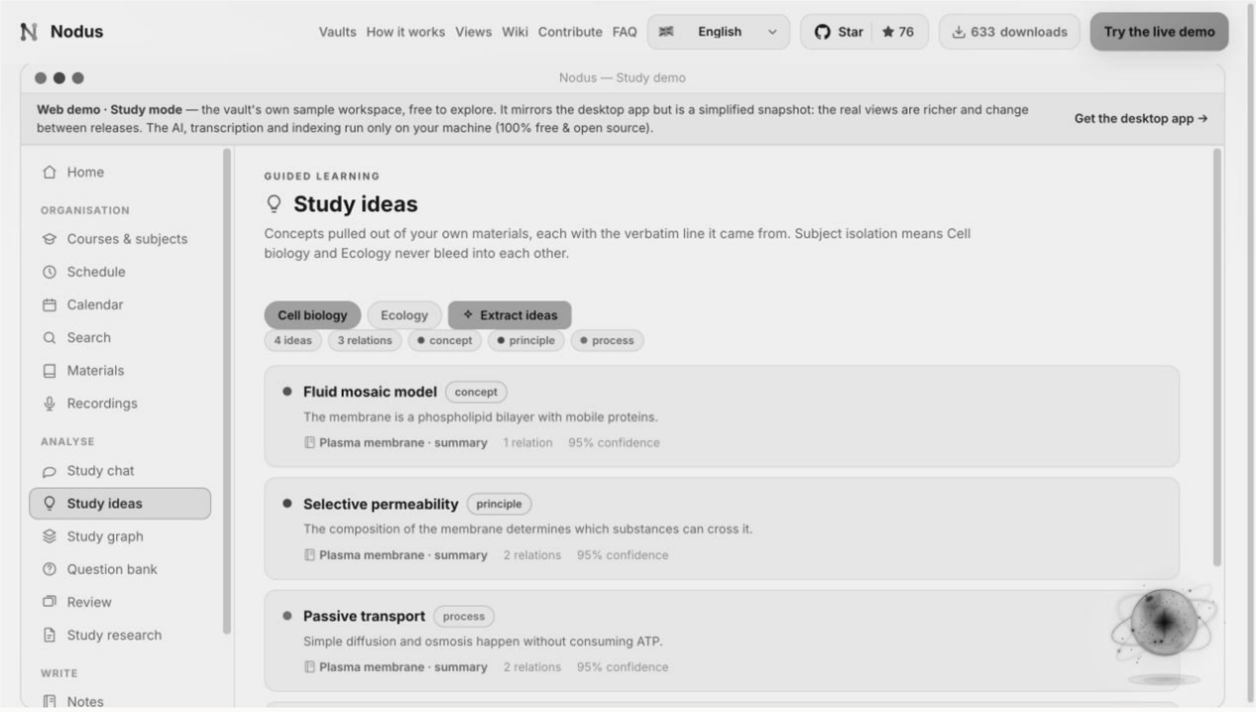
Subject isolation prevents unrelated course content from leaking into the answer. Citations lead back to the relevant note, page or transcript.

STEP BY STEP

1. Select the correct subject and check the included sources.
2. Ask for an explanation, comparison or quiz at an appropriate level.
3. Open the cited evidence and correct any unsupported statement.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Ask the tutor to question you before explaining when practising recall.



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GUIDED LEARNING

9 Study ideas

Review concepts extracted from your own notes and materials with verbatim evidence.

Ideas capture definitions, mechanisms and relationships while retaining the subject and source context.

STEP BY STEP

1. Filter ideas by subject or topic.
2. Open one and read its evidence and related ideas.
3. Correct or merge duplicate concepts before using them for questions.

GOOD PRACTICE

- A concise concept with one clear relation is easier to learn than a paragraph label.

GUIDED LEARNING

10 Study graph

Explore concepts and typed connections as a subject map.

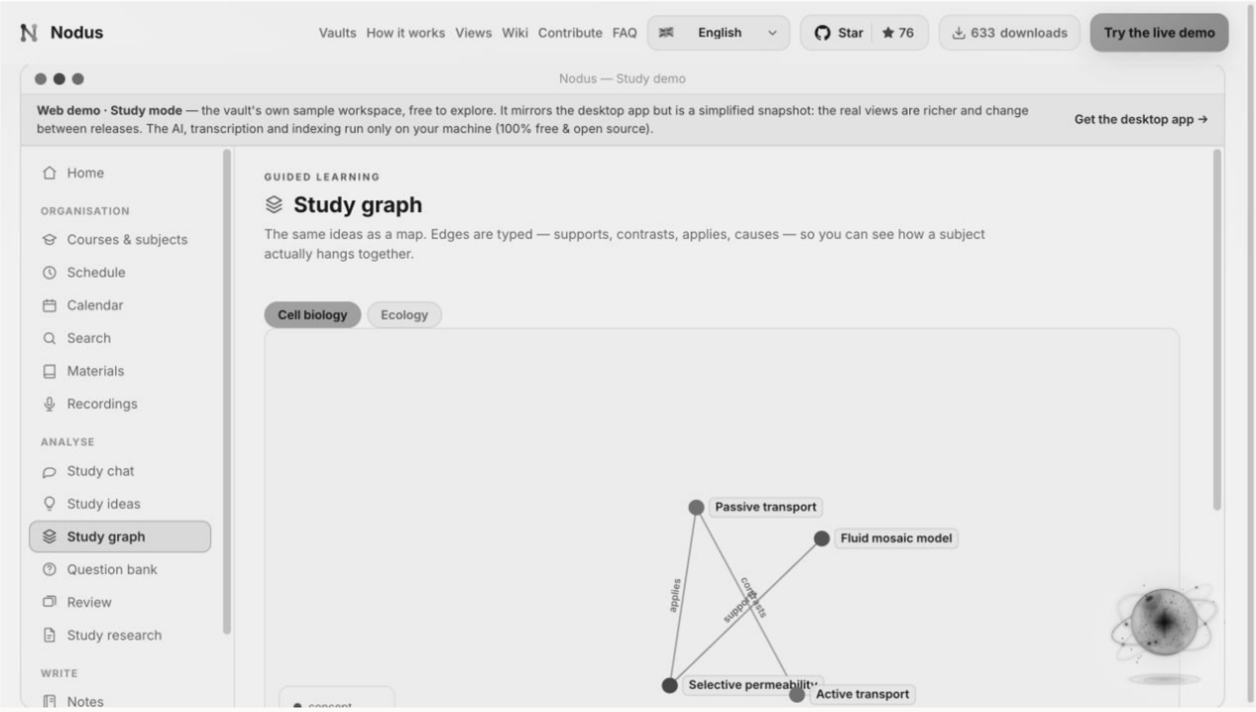
The graph shows supports, contrasts, causes and applications. It is useful for diagnosing isolated concepts and building explanations.

STEP BY STEP

1. Choose one subject and an overview or topic focus.
2. Select a node and explain its outgoing relations in your own words.
3. Open evidence for uncertain edges and repair the underlying idea if needed.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Redraw a small part from memory after exploring it.



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ASSESSMENT

11 Question bank, tests and exams

Build approved questions from specific source excerpts.

Questions can be organised by subject, topic, type and difficulty. Generated items remain drafts until reviewed and retain the evidence that justifies the answer.

STEP BY STEP

1. Create manually or generate from selected material.

2. Review wording, answer, distractors, explanation and source excerpt.

3. Approve the item, then assemble it into a practice test or exam.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Reject ambiguous questions even if the expected answer is technically present.

ASSESSMENT

12 Flashcards and spaced review

Run focused review sessions and rate recall honestly.

Review can reuse approved content or generate a bounded session. Ratings influence when material returns.

STEP BY STEP

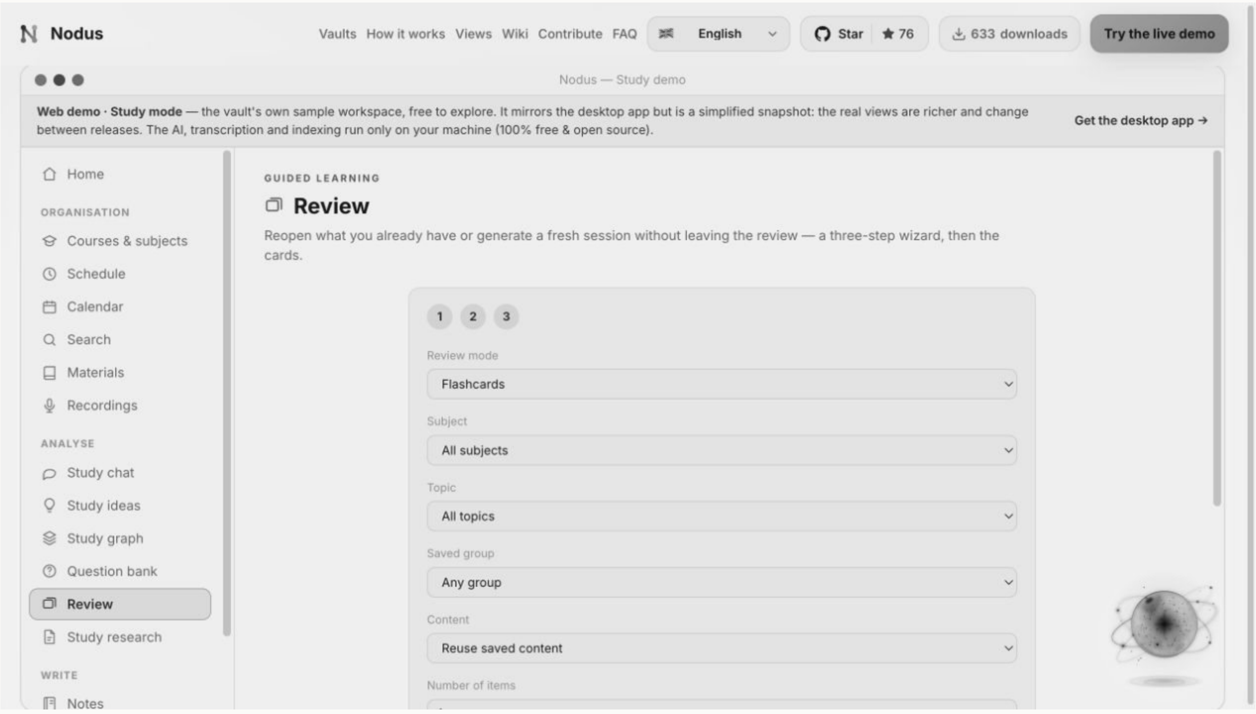
1. Choose subject, scope, session type and length.

2. Answer before revealing the back or explanation.

3. Rate recall based on retrieval quality, not familiarity after seeing the answer.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Short daily sessions outperform occasional marathon reviews.



English interface shown with the built-in sample vault.

GUIDED LEARNING

13 Study Research

Create an extended study brief grounded in selected course content.

A study brief organises explanations and citations around a learning question rather than searching the open web by default.

STEP BY STEP

1. Ask a clear question and choose the subject or source scope.
2. Start the report and wait for the queued task to complete.
3. Read actively, open citations and turn key sections into your own questions.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Use a brief as a map back into the material, not as a replacement for it.

WRITE

14 Notes

Write free-form notes alongside structured course content.

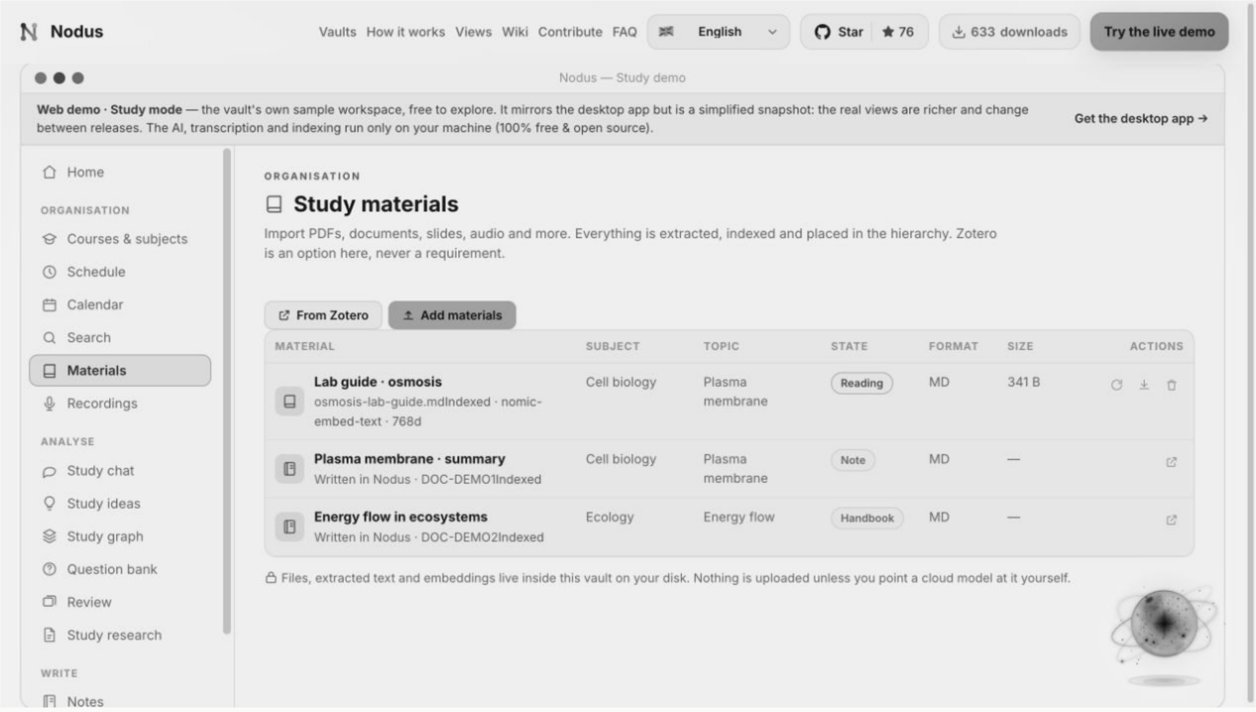
Notes can link to subjects, topics, materials and ideas. They support scratch work, summaries and reflection without losing context.

STEP BY STEP

1. Create a note under the relevant subject or topic.
2. Use headings and links to separate source notes from your interpretation.
3. Review and convert important statements into questions or ideas.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Write a short retrieval summary before reopening the source.



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CONFIGURE

15 Study settings

Control tutor models, local transcription, reminders, privacy and backups.

Study settings make the boundary between local learning tools and optional providers explicit.

STEP BY STEP

1. Choose the model for tutoring and generation, or configure a local endpoint.
2. Enable local Whisper and review microphone permissions.
3. Check reminder behaviour, AI policy and automatic backups.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Do not upload copyrighted or sensitive course material to a provider without permission.

REFERENCE

Completion checklist

- The vault scope and name match the project.
- Sources or records have preserved originals and reviewed metadata.
- Generated interpretations have been checked against their evidence.
- Optional providers and integrations use only the intended data.
- Exports have been proofread in their final format.
- A recent backup has been created and verified.

This manual documents the stable English workflow represented in Nodus 4.1. Interface details may evolve between releases; the in-app privacy notice and release notes govern the exact behaviour of the installed version.